



NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties


For Everyone
SEPT. 17, 2024

AT A GLANCE

- The National Center for Health Statistics (NCHS) has developed a system (scheme) for classifying U.S. counties by how urban or rural they are.
- Researchers can use the scheme to study issues like differences in health risk and health status between people living in urban and rural counties.



Overview

Announcement

NCHS has updated the NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties based on the 2023 Office of Management and Budget (OMB) description of metro areas.

The [National Center for Health Statistics](#) (NCHS) has developed a six-level urban-rural classification scheme for U.S. counties and other jurisdictions that are the equivalent of counties in their area. NCHS has updated the scheme based on the [2023 Office of Management and Budget \(OMB\) delineation of metropolitan and micropolitan statistical areas](#) [PDF](#) and information about all people living in each of the counties—its population—taken from Census' 2022 [postcensal estimates](#) of July 1, 2022. NCHS used these resources to classify U.S. counties and county equivalents into six categories—four metropolitan and two nonmetropolitan.

The NCHS scheme allows researchers, policy makers, and others to study American's health in relation to the urbanization level—more urban or more rural—of the place they live. They also can use NCHS data to monitor the health of people living in urban and rural areas.

2023 Urban-Rural Classification Scheme

The 2023 NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme classifies 3,144 U.S. counties. The counties include county equivalents such as parishes in Louisiana, boroughs in Alaska, and planning regions in Connecticut. They do not include county equivalents in U.S. territories.

Definitions

Metropolitan counties

1. **Large central metro** counties in metropolitan areas of 1 million population or more that—
 - Contain the entire population of the largest principal city of the metropolitan area, or
 - Are entirely contained in the largest principal city of the metropolitan area, or
 - Contain at least 250,000 residents of any principal city in the metropolitan area
2. **Large fringe metro** counties in metropolitan areas of 1 million or more population that do not qualify as large central
3. **Medium metro** counties in metropolitan areas of 250,000 to 999,999 population
4. **Small metro** counties in metropolitan areas of 50,000 to 249,999 population

Nonmetropolitan counties

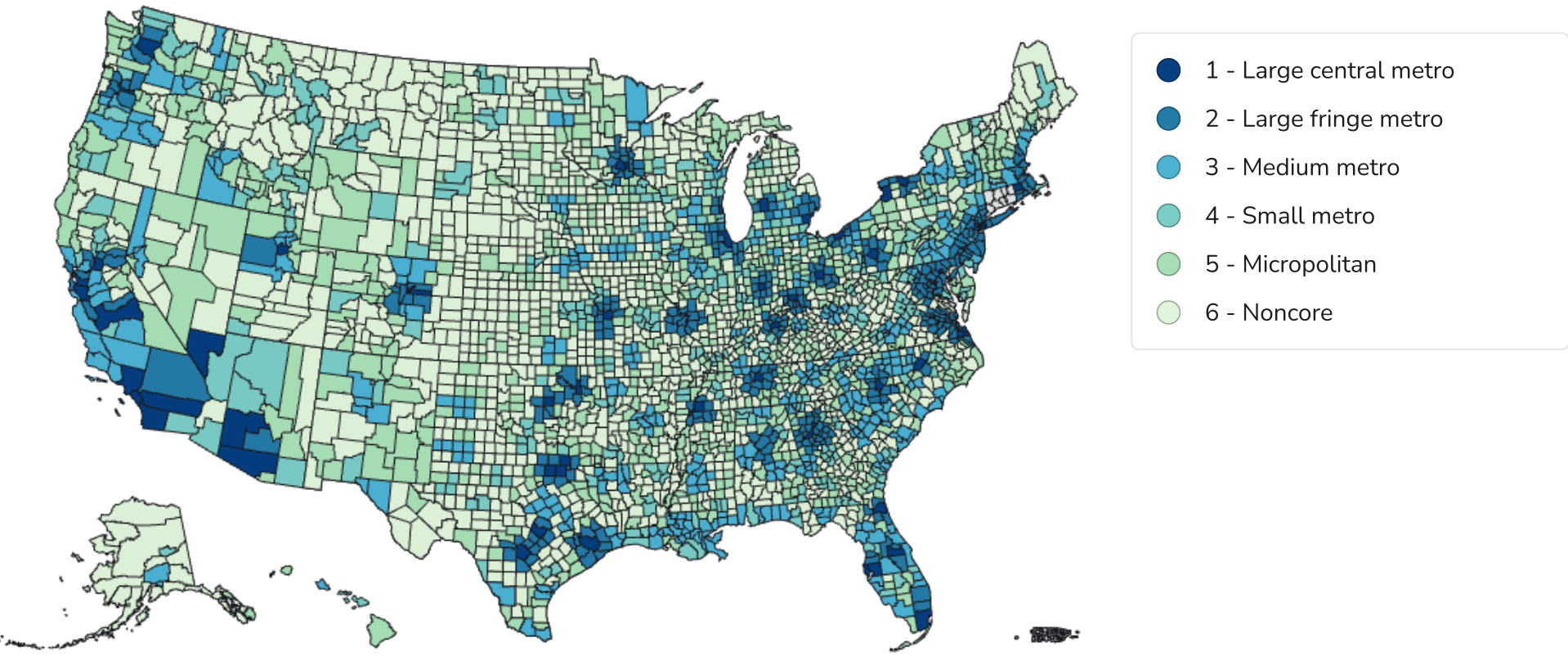
5. **Micropolitan** counties in micropolitan statistical areas

6. **Noncore** counties that did not qualify as micropolitan

2023 urban-rural levels

The 2023 Urban-Rural Classification Scheme includes 1,186 metropolitan counties and 1,958 nonmetropolitan counties. Although most counties are classified as nonmetropolitan, the majority of the U.S. population lives in metropolitan areas (86%).

	Number of counties	Percent of U.S. resident population (2022)
All counties	3,144	100%
Metropolitan counties	1,186	
Large central metro	67	30.8%
Large fringe metro	368	25.5%
Medium metro	395	21.2%
Small metro	356	8.8%
Nonmetropolitan counties	1,958	
Micropolitan	658	8.4%
Noncore	1,300	5.4%



U.S. counties and county equivalents and their classification under the 2023 NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties. The NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme does not include Puerto Rico or other U.S. territories.

Data Table

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[Download Data \(CSV\)](#)

There were minimal differences in county assignments between the 2023 and 2013 schemes. Differences in county assignments are largely due to population changes over time or to counties being added or deleted.

	2023 scheme			2013 scheme		
	Number of counties	Percent of counties	Percent of U.S. resident population (2022)	Number of counties	Percent of counties	Percent of U.S. resident population (2012)
All counties	3,144			3,143		

Metropolitan counties	1,186		86.2	1,167		85.2
Large central metro	67	2.1	30.8	68	2.2	30.5
Large fringe metro	368	11.7	25.5	368	11.7	24.7
Medium metro	395	12.6	21.2	373	11.9	20.9
Small metro	356	11.3	8.8	358	11.4	9.2
Nonmetropolitan counties	1,958		13.8	1,976		14.8
Micropolitan	658	20.9	8.4	641	20.4	8.7
Noncore	1,300	41.3	5.4	1,335	42.5	6.1

Past versions

NCHS first developed its urban-rural scheme in 2001 (referred to as the 1990 census-based scheme). NCHS has updated the scheme in 2006, 2013, and 2023.

The basic framework of the four schemes is the same. NCHS used the same classification rules to assign counties to the six urban-rural categories in the 2023, 2013, and 2006 schemes. Somewhat different classification rules were used for the 1990 census-based scheme. More information is available in the [technical and file documentation](#) PDF.

2013 NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties, based on—

- OMB's [February 2013 delineation of metropolitan statistical areas \(MSA\) and micropolitan statistical areas](#) PDF
- The [Vintage 2012 postcensal estimates](#) of the resident U.S. population

2006 NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties, based on—

- OMB's [December 2005 delineation of MSAs and micropolitan statistical areas](#) PDF
- [Vintage 2004 postcensal estimates of the resident U.S. population](#)

1990 Census-based NCHS Urban-Rural Classification Scheme for Counties, based on—

- [OMB's June 1993 delineation of MSAs](#) TXT
- [1990 census data](#)

Data files and documentation

- [NCHS Urban-Rural codes \(1990, 2006, 2013, and 2023\)](#) EXCEL
- [NCHS Urban-Rural Codes \(SAS file\)](#)
- [Technical and file documentation](#) PDF
- [2013 NCHS Urban–Rural Classification Scheme for Counties](#) PDF
- [2006 and 1990 NCHS Urban–Rural Classification Scheme for Counties](#) PDF
- [County geography](#) PDF

Related links

- [Metropolitan and micropolitan statistical areas](#)
- [USDA Economic Research Service Rural-Urban Continuum Codes](#)
- [National Center for Education Statistics \(NCES\) Locale Classifications and Criteria](#)
- [Census Bureau urban-rural classification](#)
- [CDC Office of Rural Health](#)